

URBAN REUSE / CASE HL01

THE HIGH LINE
PUBLIC REALM
From freight infrastructure
to civic operating model.
A real case of preservation, landscape,
access, programming, and stewardship.
OFFICIAL FACTS + EDITORIAL ANALYSIS
FRIENDS OF THE HIGH LINE / 2026



01 / ORIGIN

The asset was already there. The operating model was not.
A linear freight structure became a public-realm question.
2 / 10
CITY / HL01
ELEVATED INFRASTRUCTURE / 1934 → 1980
1934
1980
freight rail begins
last train
THE PUBLIC QUESTION
Demolish,
preserve, or transform?
The structure carried food and agricultural goods
above Manhattan streets. Its next use had to
carry public life instead.
The first design move was reframing.
FACTS: Friends of the High Line official fact sheet / 1934 freight structure; last
train 1980.



02 / PRESERVATION

Preservation became a civic design process
The project advanced through advocacy, public support, design, and phased delivery.
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CITY / HL01
PUBLIC PROCESS / OFFICIAL MILESTONES
1999
Friends founded
2002
City support
2004
Design team selected
2009
Section 1 opens
2011
Section 2 opens
The sequence matters: legitimacy was built before the landscape was built.
FACTS: Friends of the High Line official 2014 corporate membership brochure / milestone chronology.



03 / DESIGN LOGIC

The track bed became the design vocabulary
The strongest move preserved memory while changing use.

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EDITABLE ELEVATED SECTION / RAIL + PLANTING

rail memory + self-seeded landscape + public movement

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

Keep the trace.

Change the role.

More than one-third of the original
rail tracks are featured in the park's design.

FACT: Friends of the High Line self-guided visit / more than one-third of
original rail tracks retained in design.

NEUTRAL VISUAL FIELD

04 / OPERATING SYSTEM

A park is not only a path

The public realm works as a linked system of access, landscape, culture, and care.

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CITY / HL01

SYSTEMS MAP / NATIVE DIAGRAM

PUBLIC

REALM

PRESERVE

structure

PLANT

seasonal life

PROGRAM

art + learning

OPERATE

stewardship

VALUE IS MAINTAINED BETWEEN THE NODES.

EDITORIAL ANALYSIS: the system map is a synthesis; node labels are not a quoted project taxonomy.

NEUTRAL VISUAL FIELD

05 / SCALE

The park changed the value of an obsolete corridor
A single linear structure can carry many kinds of public use.
6 / 10
CITY / HL01
OFFICIAL SCALE / 1.45 MILES
STRUCTURE
1.45
OPEN 2009
0.62
OPEN 2011
1.0
VISITOR ROUTE
1.0
Scale is physical. Meaning is operational.
READING
Reuse creates
more than access.
It creates a platform for
landscape, culture, and
neighbourhood identity.
FACTS: official High Line fact sheet / 1.45 miles; sections opened in 2009 and
2011. Bars are editorial comparison, not attendance data.



06 / COLLABORATION

The design team was a coalition, not a single author
Landscape, architecture, planting, public agencies, and civic advocates formed one delivery system.

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COLLABORATION FIELD

FIELD OPERATIONS

landscape / project lead

shared accountability

DS+R

architecture + public realm

shared accountability

PIET OUDOLF

planting design

shared accountability

CITY + FHL

jurisdiction + stewardship

shared accountability

A memorable place requires an operating coalition behind the image.

FACT: official High Line materials identify Field Operations, Diller Scofidio +

Renfro, and Piet Oudolf as the design collaboration.

NEUTRAL VISUAL FIELD

07 / STEWARDSHIP

The project did not end at opening day
Public space becomes durable when maintenance, programming, and funding
are designed with it.
8 / 10
CITY / HL01
OPERATING LOOP / EDITORIAL MODEL
VISIT
use
PROGRAM
return
CARE
trust
FUND
continue
OPERATE THE PUBLIC REALM AS A LIVING ASSET.
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS: loop is a strategy model; it does not quantify the High
Line's operating budget or impact.



08 / TRANSFER

What should another city actually copy?

The transferable lesson is the operating logic, not the visual icon.

9 / 10

CITY / HL01

DECISION MATRIX / TRANSFERABILITY

LOCAL CAPACITY →

PUBLIC

VALUE

ICON

ACCESS

SYSTEM

TRANSFER RULE

Copy the

conditions, not the image.

preserve a trace

build a coalition

fund the afterlife

EDITORIAL ANALYSIS: matrix positions are strategic hypotheses, not a quantified benchmark of public projects.

NEUTRAL VISUAL FIELD

09 / DECISION

The High Line is a lesson in changing the role of infrastructure
Preservation became powerful when it was connected to design, stewardship,
and public use.
10 / 10
CITY / HL01
Keep the trace.
Change the role.
01
Preserve what gives the place memory.
02
Design the system around public use.
03
Fund the operating life after opening.
THE BOUNDARY
The High Line is a real case.
The transfer model is analysis.
Neither is a universal formula.
SOURCES: Friends of the High Line official fact sheet, self-guided visit, and
project materials. Editorial synthesis is labeled.

